



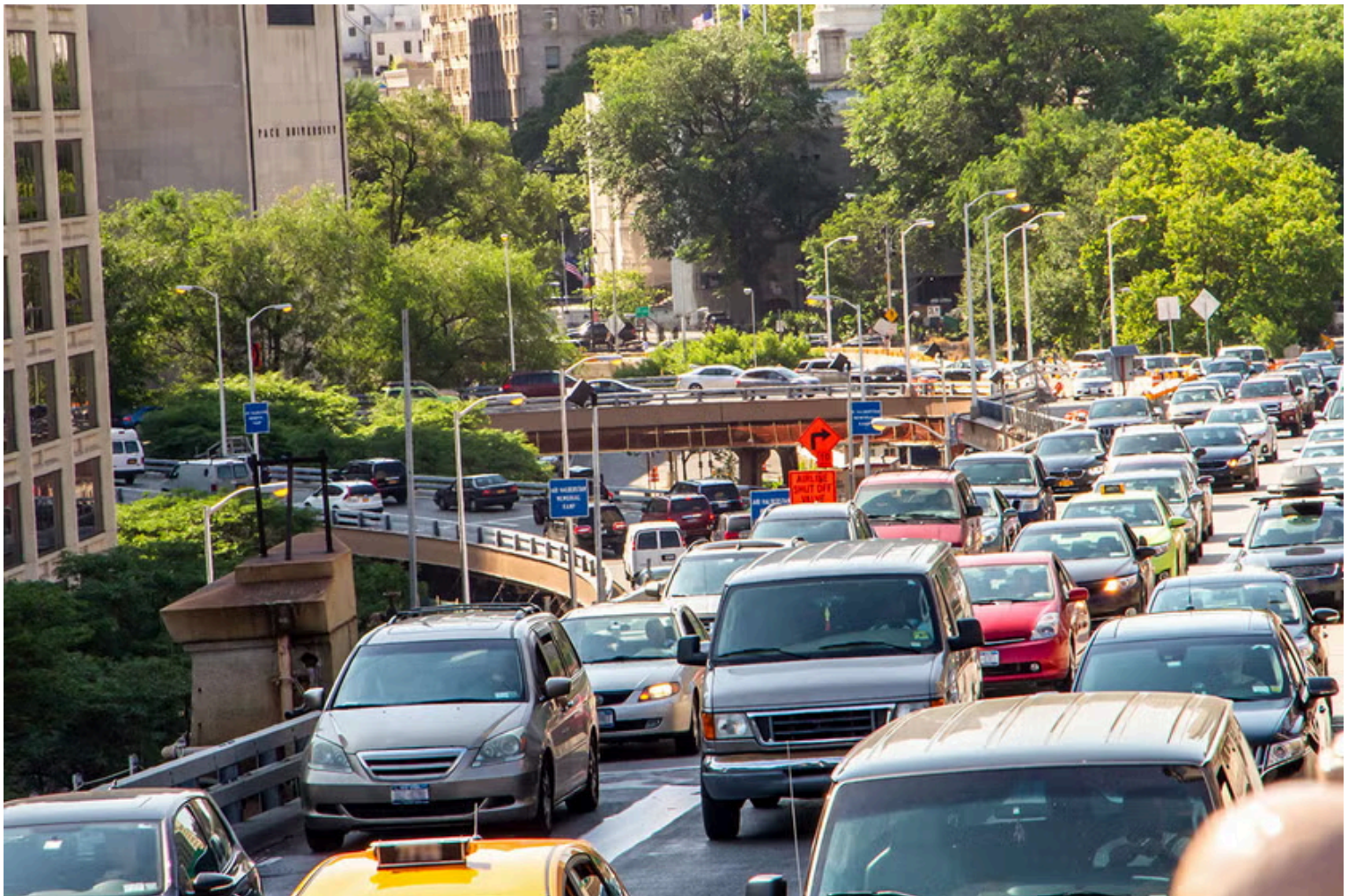
SCIENCE

Why It's So Frickin' Hard to Stop Driving

Even when better options for commuting are available, people usually don't make the switch. But there are tricks to help them.

BY DAVID ZIPPER

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Commuters are creatures of habit—until, suddenly, they aren't.

That is the conclusion of researchers, working at a number of institutions and across a variety of studies, who have examined when and why people reconfigure their journeys to regular destinations like offices and schools. Typically, travelers stick with whatever mode and route they are used to. But once in a while, an unusual event like a new job or a closed highway upends the status quo. Such disruptions can become inflection points, compelling commuters to alter travel habits that are otherwise entrenched.

Ordinarily, few people even contemplate adjusting their daily trips, regardless of other options. A 2016 study of the United Kingdom, where alternatives to driving are more plentiful than in the United States, found that only 1 in 10 car commuters shifts to another mode annually. But under certain circumstances, such changes become far more likely. The behavioral science of commuting holds powerful lessons for policymakers, civic leaders, and environmentalists hoping to convince drivers to instead use modes like public transit and biking that can ease gridlock, improve air quality, and mitigate climate change.

Switching from an SUV to using a new, direct, and protected bike lane might seem like a no-brainer—why *not* leave the hulking gas guzzler in the garage, if you can?—but it can take effort. “You might be going to work and not realize there’s a better option available,” said Ben Clark, an associate professor for transport planning at the University of the West of England, and an author on that 2016 study. In a sense, this narrow-mindedness is rational due to the myriad decisions people already juggle. “We haven’t got the mental space to be recalculating transportation options,” Clark said, shrugging.

Even if the brain does manage to focus on trip choices, its thought processes may be skewed. In a 2021 paper, a team of behavioral scientists identified a host of psychological pitfalls that reinforce existing travel habits. Status quo bias leads people to favor their current way of doing things and discount other possibilities. Present bias underweights long-term benefits, such as the financial savings that accrue over time from using transit instead of a car. Those who drive are subject to the sunk cost bias, which leads people who already own a car to feel like they *should* be using it, even if they’d save money and time by riding transit or a bike.

Collectively, those cognitive biases present a formidable obstacle to getting people to drive less. In a 2019 article in the Harvard Business Review, Ariella Kristal and Ashley Whillans describe a series of experiments they designed to help workers discover commuting options that could replace driving alone. The tools they offered a group of employees, whom they followed up with over time, included carpool matchmaking and personalized plans for using public transit. Nothing seemed to work. “Overall, we found a

whole set of interventions—many of which are used regularly in corporate settings—that *failed* to shift people’s commuting behavior,” they wrote.

Rather than throw up their hands, Kristal and Whillans recommended targeting “moments of change” in a traveler’s life, a strategy that has been borne out by other research. A Danish study, for instance, found that a month of free transit successfully boosted public transportation usage, but only among those who had recently switched their home address or job. In Britain, researchers found a similar impact from employer relocations. Those who are newly divorced are also more likely to modify their travel behavior.

These kinds of major life events create discontinuities that scramble all kinds of personal habits—and not just those regarding transportation. After welcoming a newborn, for instance, many parents adjust their shopping plans, which presents an enticing opportunity for retailers. Several years ago, Target sparked controversy by offering customized promotions to those whose purchase history suggested a pregnancy.

For transportation, personally disruptive events present brief windows to influence future travel behavior. A 2016 study found that new UCLA students were less likely to drive and more likely to use public transportation if they received information about car-free options before arriving on campus. Other research has found that free transit passes are more effective than discounts at inducing mode shift. Based on those findings, one could imagine climate-conscious public officials offering a “welcome package” of transit and bikeshare passes to those who have recently moved into a new home. Employers looking to show a commitment to sustainability (and to keeping their parking lot uncrowded) could offer the same to new hires.

Moments of discontinuity can also be triggered by external forces. In 2014, a two-day strike in the London Underground scrambled many commutes, forcing passengers to find new routes to get to work.* Researchers found that many straphangers ultimately preferred their “detour” to their traditional route, sticking with it even after the strike ended and normal service was restored. In effect, the strike prompted them to discover a better way to travel that had already been available to them. When it comes to cars, that finding suggests that a shock like a road closure might be enough to finally force people to take action and change how they commute.

“I know so many people who are in principle on the team of public transit. They’d like to take it more often,” Todd Rogers, a behavioral scientist at the Harvard Kennedy School, told me. “But then they ask, ‘Where is the station? When does the bus arrive? I’ll look into that next month.’ Even the tiniest bit of effort required makes it something they’ll

choose to do later.” During external disruptions, public campaigns promoting driving alternatives might convince such people to stop procrastinating.

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Sometimes, a disruption is much bigger than a closed road. Lockdowns during COVID showed how a disruption can affect millions of travelers at once. When commutes resumed after months of working from home, previous commuting habits were ripe for a rethink, particularly if people emerging from their homes encountered streets that were different from what they remembered.

Some European cities seized the moment. In Brussels, for instance, local officials raced to [install 40 kilometers of new bike lanes](#) while the city was in lockdown, laying the groundwork for a subsequent [surge in cycling](#).

Brussels’ success reveals both a strength and a limitation of using behavioral science to guide transportation policymaking. Over time, land use and infrastructure quality—the frequency of transit service, ease of driving, and safety of biking—will largely dictate how people travel. But nudges can tilt decisions on the margins, and they can lead people to adjust their current habits before they otherwise would have. By upgrading bike lanes during the pandemic, Brussels officials made biking a substantively more appealing option, and they did so at a time when people were more likely to reconsider how they historically travel.

“You need both,” said Clark. “You need to have a good set of alternatives to car, and then you need to layer up with behavioral support.”

Commuting habits are sticky, but that doesn’t make them permanent. 

Correction, Dec. 16, 2024: This article originally misstated that the 2014 London Underground strike lasted a month. It was two days.

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